

PRACTICAL COUPLE ITINERARY

Taiwan in 12 Days

Ahmedabad to Taiwan | 1-12 November 2026 | 11 nights

TAIPEI	TAICHUNG	ALISHAN	TAINAN	KAOHSIUNG	TAIPEI
4 nights	1 night	2 nights	2 nights	1 night	1 night

THE TRAVEL STYLE

Public transport first. One shared coach or minibus day tour for Yehliu, Shifen and Jiufen. Short taxis only where they protect a limited sightseeing window or solve a luggage gap. No Sun Moon Lake, no Okinawa, and no repeated Elephant Mountain.

WHY THIS ROUTE	WHAT TO BOOK FIRST
It gives Taipei enough depth, preserves the best mountain experience at Alishan, and adds Tainan and Kaohsiung without turning every day into a transfer day.	International flights, all hotels, and Alishan lodging now. Then use the timed rail booking windows in October.
REALISTIC BUDGET	WORKING EXCHANGE RATE
INR 3.6-5.0 lakh for two, excluding shopping. A comfortable target is INR 4.2-4.5 lakh plus a reserve.	NT\$1 = INR 3.10 for planning, deliberately above recent spot rates to cover card and FX spread.

Important

This is a planning document, not a live quotation. Airline fares, hotel taxes, tour inclusions and transport timetables can change. Where a 2026 schedule is not yet loaded, the document names the booking window and the safe planning allowance.

1. Day-wise outline and highlights

The route uses six hotel check-ins across 11 nights. Every transfer day includes a luggage plan before sightseeing.

Day	Date / sleep	Plan	Main highlight	Pace
1	Sun 1 Nov Taipei	Arrive, Airport MRT, easy Ximending evening	Low-friction arrival	Light
2	Mon 2 Nov Taipei	Historic core, Taipei 101, Elephant Mountain	Classic skyline day	Active
3	Tue 3 Nov Taipei	Shared tour: Yehliu, Shifen, Jiufen	Best-value north coast loop	Active
4	Wed 4 Nov Taipei	Beitou geothermal area and Tamsui sunset	Thermal Valley + riverside	Light
5	Thu 5 Nov Taichung	HSR south, National Taichung Theater, optional Rainbow Village	Architecture + city texture	Active
6	Fri 6 Nov Alishan	TRA to Chiayi, forest railway via Fenghu	Scenic mountain railway	Transfer
7	Sat 7 Nov Alishan	Optional sunrise, full forest trails	Cypress forest and cloud views	Active
8	Sun 8 Nov Tainan	Relaxed Alishan morning, reserved bus + HSR, Shennong Street	Mountain-to-old-city transition	Transfer
9	Mon 9 Nov Tainan	Historic center and Anping	Taiwan's strongest heritage day	Active
10	Tue 10 Nov Kaohsiung	TRA, Pier-2, Hamasen and Cijin	Harbor sunset	Active
11	Wed 11 Nov Taipei	Kaohsiung morning, HSR north, final shopping	Buffer before flight	Moderate
12	Thu 12 Nov	Airport MRT and fly home	Protected departure	Light

What is intentionally omitted

Sun Moon Lake is attractive, but it adds another intercity leg and either a rushed day trip or another hotel. Fo Guang Shan is also omitted from the core plan because the single Kaohsiung night is better spent around the harbor. Rainbow Village is optional because its small site is worthwhile only if timing remains comfortable.

2. Booking priority snapshot

The Alishan components are the only genuinely fragile pieces. Book them at their opening times, not casually later.

Item	When	Advance?	Why / action
Ahmedabad-Taipei flights	Now	YES	Book Thai or Singapore Airlines with checked baggage. Target INR 65,000-85,000 per person return.
Hotels	Now	YES	Use refundable rates first, especially Alishan weekend. Confirm luggage holding and taxes.
Visa / TAC eligibility	Now	YES	Check each traveler separately. Do not assume an Indian passport alone qualifies for TAC.
HSR: Taipei-Taichung	Around 8 Oct	YES	Sales generally open 29 days ahead; buy reserved seats, preferably early-bird.
HSR: Chiayi-Tainan	Around 11 Oct	YES	Reserve a train compatible with the Alishan bus arrival.
HSR: Zuoying-Taipei	Around 14 Oct	YES	Reserve an afternoon train; this is the longest HSR leg.
TRA: Taichung-Chiayi	Around 9 Oct	RECOMMENDED	Sales generally open 28 days ahead. Choose a train that reaches Chiayi before 09:15.
Alishan mainline train	23 Oct, 03:30 IST	CRITICAL	For Fri 6 Nov, inventory opens 15 days ahead at 06:00 Taiwan time.
Alishan sunrise train	23 Oct onward	YES	Reserve for Sat 7 Nov. Exact departure time is posted the previous afternoon.
Alishan bus to HSR Chiayi	As soon as date opens	YES	Aim for the 13:30 Route A departure, then connect to HSR.
Yehliu-Shifen-Jiufen tour	1-3 weeks ahead	YES	A shared coach/minibus is best value for two. Check pickup point and admission inclusion.
Taipei 101	Same day or 1-2 weeks	OPTIONAL	Book ahead only for a fixed sunset slot; same-day is smarter if weather is uncertain.
Thermal Valley / museums	Walk-up	NO	Thermal Valley is free and normally open Tue-Sun; check closures a day before.
Tainan / Kaohsiung sights	Walk-up	NO	General admission and ferries can be bought on arrival.
Airport MRT / metro / buses	Walk-up	NO	Tap an EasyCard; no advance booking needed.

One reminder worth setting

On Friday 23 October 2026 at 03:25 India time, be signed in and ready to buy the Chiayi-Alishan mainline train and the Alishan sunrise train. Recheck the operator's release rule one week beforehand in case it changes.

3. Detailed day-by-day plan

Daily cost bands include transport, ordinary admissions and food for two, but exclude the hotel and international flights unless stated.

DAY 1 | SUN 1 NOV

LIGHT

Arrive without over-planning

Overnight: Taipei | Pace: Light

- Land at Taoyuan Airport, complete immigration, collect luggage and buy or activate an eSIM/SIM.
- Take the Airport MRT Express to Taipei Main Station in about 35-40 minutes. Continue by MRT or a short taxi only if luggage makes the final walk awkward.
- Check in, eat near the hotel, then stroll Ximending. Keep the evening optional if the flight lands late.

HOW TO MOVE	BAGS
Airport MRT Express, then MRT or a short metered taxi. No private airport transfer is needed unless arrival is after the final train or mobility/luggage makes rail impractical.	With you until hotel check-in. Choose a Taipei Main or Ximending hotel with a staffed desk and luggage storage.
DAY COST FOR TWO	BOOKING STATUS
NT\$1,000-1,700 (INR 3,100-5,300), excluding hotel. Includes Airport MRT, EasyCard top-up and dinner.	Flight and hotel: now. Airport MRT and EasyCard: walk-up. TWAC: submit free online within 7 days before arrival.

Vegetarian food nearby

Mi Shan near Taipei Main: simple vegetarian noodles and rice, about NT\$150-300 per person. **Vege Creek:** customizable plant-based bowl, about NT\$160-250. Check the nearest open branch on the day.

DECISION NOTE

Do not schedule Taipei 101 here. Flight delays and immigration queues are too unpredictable.

DAY 2 | MON 2 NOV

ACTIVE

Historic Taipei, skyline and Elephant Mountain

Overnight: Taipei | Pace: Active

- Morning: Longshan Temple, Bopiliao Historic Block and Chiang Kai-shek Memorial Hall. All are straightforward by MRT and walking.
- Afternoon: choose the National Palace Museum if Chinese art matters to you, or keep the day more urban with Dihua Street and Xinyi. The museum requires MRT plus a public bus or a short taxi.
- Late afternoon: Taipei 101 Observatory only if visibility is good. Continue to Elephant Mountain once, for blue-hour skyline views. The climb is steep but short; turn back at the first major viewing platform if tired.

HOW TO MOVE	BAGS
MRT and walking all day. For the National Palace Museum, use MRT plus bus; a short taxi is justified only to save time. Walk from Xiangshan MRT to Elephant Mountain.	Leave all luggage at the Taipei hotel.
DAY COST FOR TWO	BOOKING STATUS
With Taipei 101: NT\$2,700-3,500 (INR 8,400-10,900). Without it: NT\$1,500-2,300. National Palace Museum adds NT\$700 for two.	Taipei 101: same day unless a sunset slot is essential. National Palace Museum: walk-up. MRT/buses: walk-up.

Vegetarian food nearby

Fruitful Food: vegetarian buffet, about NT\$700-900 per person; reserve for peak dinner. **Little Tree Food:** polished vegetarian meal, about NT\$350-700 per person; reserve if dining at a popular time.

DECISION NOTE

Monday closure patterns change by attraction. Recheck National Palace Museum and any small museums before finalizing this day.

DAY 3 | TUE 3 NOV

ACTIVE

Yehliu, Shifen and Jiufen by shared tour

Overnight: Taipei | Pace: Active

- Join a shared coach or minibus from a central Taipei pickup point. A typical loop covers Yehliu Geopark, Shifen Waterfall and Old Street, then Jiufen.
- At Shifen, one shared sky lantern is enough; treat it as optional. At Jiufen, focus on the lanes, tea-house views and evening atmosphere rather than chasing a literal Studio Ghibli connection.
- Return to Taipei in the evening. Keep dinner near the drop-off point because tour return times vary with traffic.

HOW TO MOVE	BAGS
Shared group tour is the recommendation. These sites are individually reachable by public transport, but the three-stop loop becomes slow and fragmented. A private car is not good value for two unless you want custom pacing or a later Jiufen departure.	Leave luggage at the Taipei hotel. Carry rain shells, water and a light layer; Yehliu can be windy and Jiufen can be wet.
DAY COST FOR TWO	BOOKING STATUS
NT\$3,000-4,000 (INR 9,300-12,400) including tour, Yehliu admission if not included, one lantern, meals and incidentals.	Shared tour: 1-3 weeks ahead. Verify pickup, language, Yehliu admission and exact return point. Everything else can be paid on the day.

Vegetarian food nearby

Eat a proper vegetarian breakfast before pickup. Jiufen snacks are not reliably vegetarian because broths and fillings can contain animal products. Carry a snack and ask the guide for a vegetarian stop.

DECISION NOTE

Jiufen is often marketed as the inspiration for Spirited Away, but Studio Ghibli has not officially confirmed that claim. Visit for the village itself.

DAY 4 | WED 4 NOV

LIGHT

Beitou geothermal morning and Tamsui sunset

Overnight: Taipei | Pace: Light

- Take the Red Line and Xinbeitou branch to the geothermal district. Walk the library, hot spring museum and Thermal Valley circuit.
- Optional: book a private hot spring room. This is more comfortable for a couple than a gender-separated public bath and avoids bathing-rule confusion.
- Continue by MRT to Tamsui. Walk the old street and riverside, then stay for sunset if the sky is clear. Return by Red Line.

HOW TO MOVE	BAGS
MRT plus walking. No taxi or tour is needed. The Red Line directly links Beitou and Tamsui.	Leave luggage at the Taipei hotel.
DAY COST FOR TWO	BOOKING STATUS
Without a private bath: NT\$1,500-2,300 (INR 4,700-7,100). With a private room: roughly NT\$2,700-5,300 total.	Thermal Valley and museum: walk-up, generally free. Private hot spring room: reserve 3-7 days ahead, especially for a preferred time.

Vegetarian food nearby

Use a proper vegetarian restaurant near Beitou/Xinbeitou rather than relying on old-street snacks. In Tamsui, clearly ask whether soup bases and sauces contain meat or fish.

DECISION NOTE

Thermal Valley is normally closed Monday and open Tue-Sun 09:00-17:00. Recheck official hours the day before.

DAY 5 | THU 5 NOV

ACTIVE

HSR south, theater architecture and optional Rainbow Village

Overnight: Taichung | Pace: Active

- Check out and take HSR from Taipei to Taichung. At HSR Taichung, transfer to a local train for TRA Taichung Station or use the most direct bus for your hotel.
- Drop bags at a hotel near TRA Taichung. Visit National Taichung Theater; its public spaces and architecture are the priority.
- Add Rainbow Village only if arrival is early and energy is good. Finish at a night market or central shopping area, but use a vegetarian restaurant for the main meal.

HOW TO MOVE	BAGS
HSR for the intercity leg. Taichung's sights are dispersed; MRT/bus works, but two or three short taxi/Uber hops are justified on this one-night stop and cost less than losing hours in transfers.	Take bags to the hotel first. Staying near TRA Taichung makes the next morning's train to Chiayi easier.
DAY COST FOR TWO	BOOKING STATUS
NT\$3,700-4,800 (INR 11,500-14,900), excluding hotel. Includes HSR, local movement, food and modest incidentals.	HSR: reserve when sales open, around 8 Oct. Theater public areas and Rainbow Village: walk-up; recheck opening hours. Taxis/buses: instant.

Vegetarian food nearby

EasySuYuan near Taichung Station: affordable vegetarian fare, about NT\$100-200 per person. **BAA Veg Indian Cuisine:** useful for a familiar dinner, about NT\$200-600 per person.

DECISION NOTE

Rainbow Village is small. Skip it if it forces you to rush the theater or creates a long cross-city detour.

DAY 6 | FRI 6 NOV

TRANSFER

Chiayi connection and Alishan Forest Railway

Overnight: Alishan | Pace: Transfer

- Take an early reserved TRA train from Taichung to Chiayi and arrive with at least 40 minutes before the mountain train.
- Board the 10:00 Alishan Forest Railway mainline. Current pattern: Fenqihu around 12:16, depart around 13:21, Alishan around 14:56. Use the stop for lunch and a short walk, but obey the train time.
- Use the hotel's pickup or local shuttle, check in, then take only a short sunset or station-area walk. Save the forest circuit for tomorrow.

HOW TO MOVE	BAGS
Reserved TRA plus reserved Alishan Forest Railway. This is not a day for a taxi from Taichung; the railway is the experience. Confirm the Alishan hotel shuttle before travel.	Critical: the forest railway states total belongings up to 15 kg per person, each piece up to 100 cm and total dimensions up to 200 cm. If your suitcases are larger, forward them Taichung-to-Tainan and take cabin bags to Alishan.
DAY COST FOR TWO	BOOKING STATUS
NT\$3,200-4,300 (INR 9,900-13,300), excluding hotel. Includes TRA estimate, NT\$1,200 forest train for two, park entry and meals.	TRA: around 9 Oct. Alishan mainline: target 23 Oct at 03:30 IST. Hotel shuttle and vegetarian dinner: confirm now. Park admission: on arrival.

Vegetarian food nearby

Eat or buy a simple vegetarian lunch during the Fenqihu stop only if service is fast. Carry a backup meal. At Alishan, request vegetarian breakfast/dinner in writing before arrival; allow NT\$250-450 per person per meal.

DECISION NOTE

Do not build a tight connection at Chiayi. Missing the 10:00 mountain train would damage the entire Alishan plan.

DAY 7 | SAT 7 NOV

ACTIVE

Sunrise option and full forest day

Overnight: Alishan | Pace: Active

- Optional pre-dawn Zhushan sunrise train. Clouds are possible; the experience is still atmospheric, but it is not guaranteed.
- After breakfast and rest, walk the Zhaoping, Sister Ponds, giant cypress and Sacred Tree circuit. Use one branch train or electric shuttle to avoid unnecessary backtracking.
- Keep late afternoon flexible for cloud-sea viewpoints, tea or an early dinner. This is your second Alishan night, so nothing needs to be rushed.

HOW TO MOVE	BAGS
Branch railway, electric shuttle and walking. No car or private guide is required inside the recreation area.	Leave everything at the Alishan hotel. Carry only a daypack, rain shell and warm layer.
DAY COST FOR TWO	BOOKING STATUS
NT\$1,700-2,700 (INR 5,300-8,400), excluding hotel. Includes branch trains/shuttle and meals.	Sunrise train: reserve from the 15-day window. The exact departure time is announced around 16:30 the previous day. Other branch tickets: day before or on the day.

Vegetarian food nearby

Hotel breakfast is the safest early option. For lunch and dinner, use the visitor-area eateries only after confirming vegetarian broth and no lard. Carry nuts, fruit or an instant meal as backup.

DECISION NOTE

November brings evergreen cypress, moss, mist and a reasonable cloud-sea chance. Full red maple color is more typical later, often around December; cherry blossom season is not November.

DAY 8 | SUN 8 NOV

TRANSFER

Easy Alishan morning, then south to Tainan

Overnight: Tainan | Pace: Transfer

- Have a relaxed breakfast and one short forest or viewpoint walk. Check out and leave bags with the hotel.
- Take the reserved Alishan Route A bus to THSR Chiayi. The current useful pattern is about 13:30-16:10; verify the 2026 timetable before booking.
- HSR to Tainan, then public shuttle/rail connection or taxi to West Central District. Check in and stroll Shennong Street after dark.

HOW TO MOVE	BAGS
Reserved tourist shuttle bus, then HSR. From THSR Tainan, local rail/bus is cheapest; a taxi to the central hotel is justified after a long mountain transfer and with luggage.	Hotel holds bags after checkout. Keep bags with you on bus/HSR, then go directly to the Tainan hotel before sightseeing.
DAY COST FOR TWO	BOOKING STATUS
NT\$2,700-3,500 (INR 8,400-10,900), excluding hotel. Includes bus, HSR, final transfer and meals.	Alishan bus: reserve as soon as inventory opens. HSR Chiayi-Tainan: around 11 Oct, matched to bus arrival. Local transfer: instant.

Vegetarian food nearby

For a late arrival, ask the hotel for a nearby vegetarian restaurant still serving. **Guli Natural Vegan Restaurant** is a good central option when open, about NT\$250-450 per person.

DECISION NOTE

Do not choose a very tight HSR connection. Mountain road traffic and weather can delay the bus.

DAY 9 | MON 9 NOV

ACTIVE

Taiwan's strongest heritage day

Overnight: Tainan | Pace: Active

- Walk the historic core: Confucius Temple area, Hayashi Department Store, lanes and old streets. Choose paid interiors selectively.
- After lunch, go to Anping Fort and the old settlement area. Add Anping Tree House only if it genuinely interests you and closing time allows.
- Return to West Central District for an unhurried evening. Tainan works best through streets, food and layered history, not a checklist of every temple.

HOW TO MOVE	BAGS
Walk the central core. For Anping, a city bus is possible, but two short taxi rides are recommended to protect limited time. No all-day private car is needed.	Leave luggage at the Tainan hotel.
DAY COST FOR TWO	BOOKING STATUS
NT\$2,400-3,700 (INR 7,400-11,500) for local movement, admissions and meals.	General attractions: walk-up. Anping Fort currently NT\$70 per adult. Restaurant reservation only for a popular dinner.

Vegetarian food nearby

Guli Natural Vegan Restaurant: central and convenient, about NT\$250-450 per person. **San Yuan Zhai:** simpler local vegetarian food, about NT\$100-250. Verify Monday opening before travel.

DECISION NOTE

Some independent restaurants close on Monday. Save two backup vegetarian places in Maps before leaving the hotel.

DAY 10 | TUE 10 NOV

ACTIVE

Harbor art, old railway district and Cijin sunset

Overnight: Kaohsiung | Pace: Active

- Take TRA from Tainan to Kaohsiung. Drop bags near Yancheng or Pier-2.
- Explore Pier-2 Art Center and Hamasen by light rail and walking. Continue to Gushan ferry pier.
- Take the public ferry to Cijin for the seafront and sunset, then return for dinner around Yancheng.

HOW TO MOVE	BAGS
TRA, Kaohsiung MRT/light rail, walking and public ferry. A taxi is needed only for a luggage-heavy station-to-hotel hop. The harbor corridor is very well connected.	Go directly to the hotel first. If the room is not ready, leave luggage at reception.
DAY COST FOR TWO	BOOKING STATUS
NT\$2,000-3,100 (INR 6,200-9,600), excluding hotel. Pier-2 and general harbor access are free.	TRA limited express: reserve when the 28-day window opens if timing matters; frequent local trains can be bought same day. Light rail, MRT and ferry: walk-up.

Vegetarian food nearby

Hong Jiankang Vegetarian in Yancheng: casual buffet/quick meal, about NT\$100-200 per person. **Little Star Diner:** near Pier-2, about NT\$250-450 per person; verify current hours.

DECISION NOTE

Cijin is worthwhile for the ferry-and-harbor experience even if you skip beach time. Fo Guang Shan is not included because it would consume most of this short Kaohsiung stay.

DAY 11 | WED 11 NOV

MODERATE

Kaohsiung morning, HSR north and final shopping

Overnight: Taipei | Pace: Moderate

- Use the morning for any missed harbor area, Dome of Light, or a slow breakfast. Keep the plan close to the MRT.
- Collect bags and take MRT to Zuoying HSR. Ride a reserved afternoon train to Taipei, check in, then shop in Ximending, Taipei Main underground malls or Xinyi depending interest.
- This Taipei night is deliberate flight protection. It avoids trusting a same-day long transfer before an international departure.

HOW TO MOVE	BAGS
Kaohsiung MRT, HSR, then Taipei MRT. No taxi is necessary unless bags make the last hotel connection difficult.	Leave luggage with the Kaohsiung hotel after checkout, collect before HSR, then take it directly to the final Taipei hotel.
DAY COST FOR TWO	BOOKING STATUS
NT\$4,700-5,600 (INR 14,600-17,400), excluding hotel and shopping. HSR is NT\$2,980 for two at standard reserved fare.	Zuoying-Taipei HSR: around 14 Oct. Final Taipei hotel: now. Metro and shopping: walk-up.

Vegetarian food nearby

Use a known vegetarian chain such as Vege Creek for a quick meal. For a final nicer dinner, reserve Little Tree Food or another clearly vegetarian restaurant near your shopping district.

DECISION NOTE

Shopping is excluded from the trip budget. Taiwan is good for stationery, tea, pineapple cakes, electronics accessories and design goods; compare electronics warranties with India before buying.

DAY 12 | THU 12 NOV

LIGHT

Protected departure day

Overnight: **Flight home** | Pace: **Light**

- Check out and take Airport MRT from Taipei Main. Allow enough time for the hotel-to-station walk, airline check-in and immigration.
- If the flight is late, leave bags at the hotel and do only nearby shopping. Do not add an out-of-city excursion.

HOW TO MOVE	BAGS
Taipei MRT/walking plus Airport MRT Express. A taxi to the airport is unnecessary unless the flight departs before rail service or baggage is unmanageable.	Hotel storage if needed, then with you to the airport.
DAY COST FOR TWO	BOOKING STATUS
NT\$700-1,200 (INR 2,200-3,700), excluding flight. Includes Airport MRT and a simple meal.	Flight: now. Airport MRT: walk-up. Check airline online check-in timing the day before.

Vegetarian food nearby

Use the hotel area or airport. Keep a vegetarian snack in case the airline meal or airport choice is limited.

DECISION NOTE
Request vegetarian airline meals in the booking at least 48 hours before departure, then verify again at check-in.

4. Hotels by overnight base

Rates are per room per night for two and are deliberately broad enough to allow tax and refundable-rate differences. Breakfast inclusion varies. Book refundable rooms now, then recheck once rail inventory opens.

Base / nights	Recommended area and hotel	Planning band	Why it fits / booking check
Taipei / 5	Ximending or Taipei Main CityInn Hotel Plus Ximending Alt: Hotel Relax / Orange Hotel Ximen	NT\$2,800-4,200 INR 8,700-13,000	Fast MRT access and easy Airport MRT/HSR connections. Book the same hotel for the final night if price is sensible. Ask about luggage storage and windowed rooms.
Taichung / 1	Near TRA Taichung 53 Hotel Alt: a well-rated station hotel	NT\$2,000-3,000 INR 6,200-9,300	Walkable to TRA for the early Chiayi train and near Miyahara. Confirm front desk hours and early checkout.
Alishan / 2	Inside recreation area Alishan Shermuh International Tourist Hotel Alt: Chinshan Villa / Alishan Gou Hotel	NT\$4,000-6,500 INR 12,400-20,200	This is the least flexible stay. Book now. Confirm station pickup, heater, breakfast time, vegetarian meals and luggage holding after checkout.
Tainan / 2	West Central District U.I.J Hotel & Hostel, private room Alt: FX Hotel MinSheng / Roots Chew	NT\$3,000-4,500 INR 9,300-14,000	Best for walking the historic core and Shennong Street. Check whether room has a private bathroom and whether tax is included.
Kaohsiung / 1	Yancheng / Pier-2 City Suites Kaohsiung Pier2 Alt: Legend Hotel Pier2	NT\$1,800-3,000 INR 5,600-9,300	Near light rail, Pier-2 and ferry corridor. Check distance from the exact LRT stop and morning luggage storage.

Hotel total

A realistic range is about INR 98,000-151,000 for 11 nights. The largest swing is the two-night Alishan weekend and refundable Taipei rates. A sensible hotel target is INR 115,000-130,000 if booked soon.

Luggage forwarding option

If your checked suitcases exceed Alishan Forest Railway limits, ask the Taichung and Tainan hotels whether they accept Black Cat / T-Cat hotel-to-hotel delivery. Ordinary luggage is typically limited to 150 cm total dimensions and 20 kg, but hotel acceptance and delivery timing must be confirmed. Pack two nights in cabin bags and send the large case ahead.

5. Vegetarian strategy

Taiwan is manageable for vegetarians, but the risk is hidden broth, lard, fish seasoning and night-market cross-contamination. Use dedicated vegetarian restaurants for main meals and treat market snacks as optional.

Base	Reliable style	Typical cost for two	Practical note
Taipei	Mi Shan, Vege Creek; Fruitful Food or Little Tree Food for a nicer meal	NT\$350-1,800	Many choices. Reserve only popular buffet or dinner slots.
Taichung	EasySuYuan; BAA Veg Indian Cuisine	NT\$250-1,200	Eat a proper dinner rather than depending on night-market stalls.
Alishan	Hotel meals plus backup snacks	NT\$500-900 per meal	Request vegetarian meals in writing. Carry emergency food for sunrise and railway day.
Tainan	Guli Natural Vegan; San Yuan Zhai; hotel-recommended backup	NT\$300-900	Monday closures are common; save two backups before Day 9.
Kaohsiung	Hong Jiankang; Little Star Diner	NT\$250-900	Both fit the Yancheng/Pier-2 route; verify current hours.

Useful food terms

Su shi means vegetarian. **Quan su / chun su** generally means vegan. **Dan nai su** means egg-and-dairy vegetarian. Show a translated note that says: no meat, fish, seafood, fish sauce, lard or meat broth. If you eat onion and garlic, mention that separately because Buddhist vegetarian food may exclude them.

Daily food allowance

Budget NT\$1,500-2,000 per day for two on most days, with a little more for a Taipei buffet or Alishan hotel dinner. Across 12 days, NT\$18,000-24,000 (about INR 56,000-74,000) is a realistic allowance without luxury dining.

6. Realistic total budget for two

This estimate avoids a false low number. It assumes decent 3-star or strong budget hotels, checked baggage, a shared north-coast tour, vegetarian restaurant meals, and a few short taxis where they materially help.

Category	Couple budget	What is included
Return flights AMD-TPE	INR 130,000-170,000	Thai or Singapore Airlines planning allowance, checked baggage; book now.
Visa / authorization	INR 0 or 9,000-11,000	TAC can be free if each traveler qualifies; otherwise visitor visa, photos and handling allowance.
Hotels, 11 nights	INR 98,000-151,000	Five Taipei, one Taichung, two Alishan, two Tainan, one Kaohsiung.
Intercity + airport travel	INR 26,000-33,000	Airport MRT, HSR, TRA, Alishan rail and Alishan bus.
Local transport	INR 12,000-19,000	Metro, buses, light rail, ferry and selected taxis.
Tour + admissions	INR 19,000-25,000	Shared north-coast tour, main admissions and branch trains; excludes optional hot spring room.
Vegetarian food	INR 56,000-74,000	Restaurant meals, snacks and Alishan premium.
Insurance, eSIM, laundry, misc.	INR 15,000-25,000	Travel insurance, connectivity and contingency items.
TOTAL	INR 360,000-500,000	Shopping excluded. Add INR 9,000-11,000 if standard visas are required.

Recommended working target

Hold INR 420,000-450,000 as the expected spend and keep roughly 10% outside it as a reserve. If hotels land at the top of the band and flights are bought late, the trip can approach INR 500,000. A private Yehliu-Jiufen-Shifen car would add roughly INR 14,000-22,000 over the shared-tour plan.

Not included

Shopping, premium alcohol, luxury meals, medical costs, a private north-coast charter, an optional private hot spring room, and unusually high festival/weekend hotel pricing.

7. Connectivity and ticket cheat sheet

Leg / place	Recommended mode	Reserve?	Planning cost for two
Taoyuan Airport-Taipei	Airport MRT Express	No	NT\$320 one way
Taipei city	MRT + walking; bus for Palace Museum	No	NT\$300-500 per full day
North coast loop	Shared coach/minibus tour	Yes, 1-3 weeks	About NT\$2,000-2,500 incl. basic extras
Taipei-Taichung	HSR reserved seats	Yes, 29-day window	NT\$1,400 standard fare
Taichung city	Bus/MRT plus 2-3 short taxis	No	NT\$1,000-1,500 for the day
Taichung-Chiayi	TRA reserved train	Recommended, 28 days	Approx. NT\$500-700
Chiayi-Alishan	Forest Railway mainline	Yes, critical	NT\$1,200
Inside Alishan	Branch rail + shuttle + walking	Sunrise yes; others flexible	NT\$500-900 depending rides
Alishan-THSR Chiayi	Route 7329 tourist shuttle	Yes	NT\$566
Chiayi-Tainan	HSR	Yes	NT\$560 standard fare
Tainan city / Anping	Walk + two short taxis	No	NT\$600-1,000
Tainan-Kaohsiung	TRA	Optional for limited express	Approx. NT\$200-300
Kaohsiung harbor	MRT + LRT + ferry	No	NT\$300-600
Zuoying-Taipei	HSR reserved seats	Yes, 29-day window	NT\$2,980 standard fare

Can you really move this easily?

Yes. Taipei and Kaohsiung have excellent urban rail; intercity HSR/TRA is efficient; Tainan's center is walkable; and Alishan has a workable rail-bus system. Taichung is the weak point for compact sightseeing, which is why a few short taxis are included. The rule throughout is: hotel first, bags down, then sightseeing.

8. Entry, weather and final checklist

Entry formalities

- Check Travel Authorization Certificate eligibility separately for each Indian passport holder. Eligibility depends on qualifying documents; do not rely on nationality alone.
- If not eligible, use the standard visitor-visa process and allow time for documentation or an interview. The tourist eVisa route for Indian nationals is not a general independent-traveler shortcut.
- Complete the free Taiwan Arrival Card online within 7 days before arrival. Use only the official government site.
- Carry passport validity, return flight, hotel confirmations, itinerary, insurance and proof of funds in an offline folder.

November conditions

- Taipei and the north coast: mild, sometimes windy or drizzly. Light daytime clothes plus a sweater/light jacket and rain shell make sense because weather and indoor air-conditioning vary.
- Tainan and Kaohsiung: usually warmer. Lightweight clothes are appropriate, with one layer for evenings and trains.
- Alishan: materially colder, especially before sunrise. Pack a fleece or light insulated jacket, long trousers, a rain shell and shoes with grip.
- The forest should look beautiful in November through evergreen cypress, moss, mist and cloud views. Do not expect peak red maple color or cherry blossoms.

Final book-and-check list

Timing	Action
Now	Flights; refundable hotels; Alishan hotel; visa/TAC check; passports; travel insurance comparison.
Early-mid Oct	HSR and TRA tickets as each window opens; restaurant shortlist; luggage-forwarding confirmation.
23 Oct, 03:30 IST	Alishan mainline and sunrise train booking target; verify release rule one week earlier.
1-3 weeks before	Yehliu-Shifen-Jiufen shared tour; any Taipei sunset slot; optional private hot spring room.
Within 7 days before arrival	Free Taiwan Arrival Card; eSIM; offline confirmations; weather check; vegetarian meal confirmation.
Day before each leg	Recheck platform, timetable, closures, weather and hotel shuttle. Screenshot QR codes.

Bottom line

The itinerary is active but reasonable for a young couple. It uses public transport almost everywhere, protects every luggage transition, and spends money on the parts that actually improve the trip: Alishan logistics, a good north-coast loop and well-located hotels.

9. Official links and planning sources

Use these links to verify final schedules, eligibility and prices before payment. Hotel and restaurant examples are suggestions, not endorsements or guaranteed live rates.

1. [Taiwan entry: BOCA TAC eligibility](#)
2. [Taiwan entry: standard visitor visa requirements](#)
3. [Taiwan Arrival Card](#)
4. [Taiwan HSR booking and early-bird rules](#)
5. [Taiwan HSR fares](#)
6. [TRA reservation information](#)
7. [Alishan Forest Railway booking](#)
8. [Alishan Forest Railway timetable](#)
9. [Alishan Forest Railway fares](#)
10. [Alishan luggage rules](#)
11. [Alishan Route A bus](#)
12. [Alishan bus reservation portal](#)
13. [Airport MRT visitor information](#)
14. [Taipei 101 Observatory tickets](#)
15. [National Palace Museum admission](#)
16. [Yehliu Geopark admission](#)
17. [Beitou Thermal Valley](#)
18. [Anping Fort](#)
19. [Example shared north-coast tour](#)
20. [Singapore Airlines Ahmedabad-Taipei](#)
21. [Thai Airways flights to Taipei](#)
22. [Taipei hotel: CityInn Plus Ximending](#)
23. [Taichung hotel: 53 Hotel](#)

Prepared for planning in September 2026. Reconfirm every timed service against the operator's live page before payment.